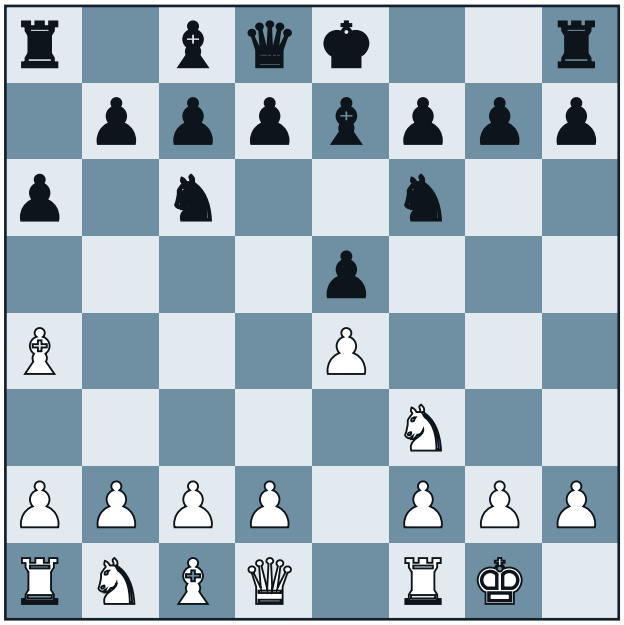
Chess Opening Repertoire Atlas

A complete guide to major chess openings for White and Black: strong variations, ideas, pawn structures, best pieces and plans, with diagrams and an engine-assisted repertoire builder.



Ruy Lopez: the start of a classical repertoire

Contents

Part I – Opening concepts, pawn structures, piece play, plans, study method

Part II – White repertoire: 10 openings

Part III – Black repertoire: 15 openings

Part IV – Repertoire builder: style matrix, ready-made repertoires, checklists

All move lines in this document were checked move-by-move for legality with the python-chess library, and evaluated with Stockfish.

Part I – Opening Concepts

An opening repertoire is a set of plans, not a pile of moves. Learn the idea, the pawn structure and the typical piece placement first; the move orders then become easy to remember.

1. The ten opening principles

• **Control the center** with pawns (e4, d4, c4) or with pieces from a distance (hypermodern play).

• **Develop knights before bishops**, and develop every minor piece once; do not move the same piece twice without reason.

• **Castle early** (usually within the first 8-10 moves); connect the rooks.

• **Do not take pawns that cost tempo** and do not bring the queen out early unless it gains something concrete.

• **Make threats, parry threats**: before each move ask 'what does my opponent want?'.

• **Pawn breaks** (c5, e5, f4, ...c5, ...e5, ...f5) decide the middlegame; know your break before you choose the opening.

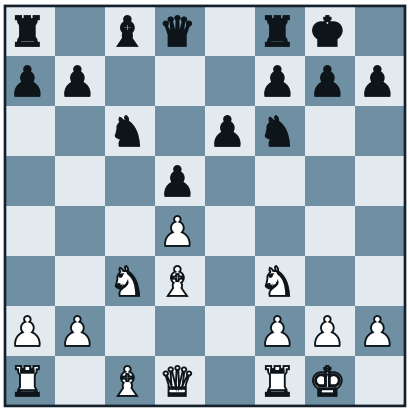
• **Keep the bishop pair** in open positions; knights are better in closed ones.

• **Do not open the center when your king is uncastled** and the opponent is better developed.

• **Use tactics to test principles**: pins, forks and discovered attacks decide most opening traps.

• **Know the structure**: pawn structure dictates plans for 20 moves; pieces follow the pawns.

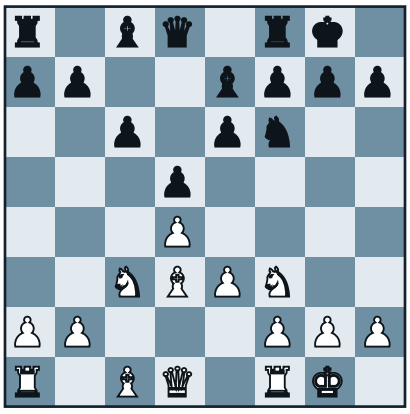
2. Core pawn structures (with diagrams)



Isolated Queen's Pawn (IQP)

Isolated Queen's Pawn (IQP)

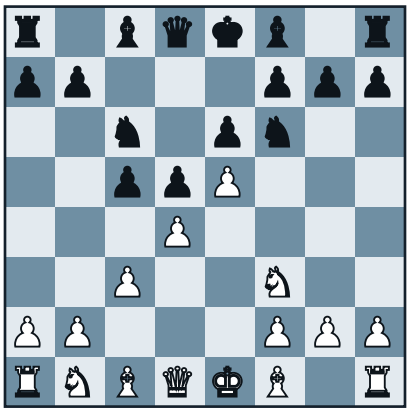
White owns the d4 pawn with no c/e neighbours. It cannot be defended by pawns, but gives space and open files. White: attack, piece activity, e4/d5 breaks, avoid queen-side endgames. Black: blockade d5, trade pieces, aim for the endgame where the pawn is weak.



Carlsbad (Exchange QGD)

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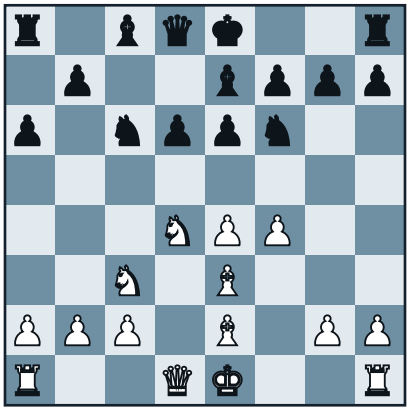
White has e3/d4 against Black's c6/d5/e6. White plays the minority attack (b4-b5) to create a weak c6/c7 pawn. Black counters with ...Ne4, ...f5 or a kingside space gain. Keep the knight on e5 or d2 for activity.



French Chain

French Chain

The pawn chain e5/d4 versus e6/d5. Attack the base of the chain: Black hits d4 with ...c5, ...Qb6 and ...Nc6; White hits e5's support or goes after the kingside. Remember: base of the pawn chain is the target.



Open Sicilian (Scheveningen)

Open Sicilian (Scheveningen)

White has e4 with a central space edge; Black has the half-open c-file and a flexible d6/e6 setup. Black's plan: ...Qc7, ...b5, ...Bb7 and ...d5 to equalize; White's plan: f4-f5 or g4-g5 for a kingside attack.

3. Piece placement

Knights love outposts (a square protected by a pawn that no enemy pawn can attack): d5/e5 for White, d4/e4 for Black. **Bishops** need open diagonals; trade off your bad bishop (blocked by your own pawns) or open the position. **Rooks** belong on open or half-open files; connect them with queen and king safe. **The queen** develops late and should not wander without a target. **The king** belongs castled; remove it from the center before the center opens.

4. Plans by pawn structure

• **Open center (e4 e5):** develop quickly, castle, fight for the e- and d-files; tactics decide.

• **Closed center (Ruy Lopez, KID):** maneuver knights to good squares; play on the wing where you have more space (kingside for KID Black, queenside for White).

• **Queen's Gambit structures:** minority attack (b4-b5) vs hanging or isolated pawns; use e4 when Black is cramped.

• **Sicilian structures:** White attacks the kingside with f4-g4 or Be3-Qd2-O-O-O; Black counterattacks with ...b5 and ...Rc8 on the queenside.

• **French / Caro-Kann:** attack the base of the pawn chain; improve the 'bad' bishop or trade it.

• **Hedgehog / Maroczy:** White clamps d5 and b5; Black waits with ...a6, ...b6, ...Be7 and prepares ...b5 or ...d5.

5. Move orders and transpositions

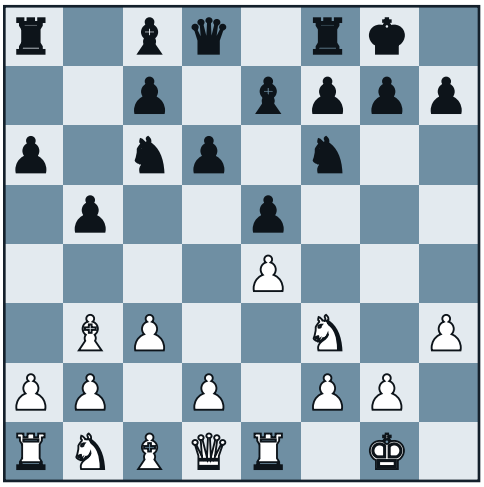
Many openings transpose: the Slav and Queen's Gambit can reach the same structure; Reti / English / Catalan share the fianchetto setup; the Italian and the Ruy Lopez can transposition to similar closed centers. Learn the target position and the set of plans so that move-order tricks do not catch you off guard.

6. How to study an opening

- Play the main line on a board and say aloud the idea of every move.
- Learn two sidelines per opening, not twenty; know the most common deviations.
- Play 10-20 training games with the line against an engine or friend, then review where you left theory.
- Keep a notebook (or PGN file) with your own mistakes; update the repertoire after every tournament.
- Drill tactics from your openings (pins, sacrifices, typical traps) 15 minutes a day.
- Study master games in your openings; pay attention to plans, not just moves.
- Use an engine only after you form your own conclusion; ask 'why did it prefer that move?'.

Part II – White Repertoire

Ruy Lopez (Closed)



Position after: c3 O-O h3

The classical main line: long-term pressure on e5 with a flexible center.

ECO C84-C99 | style: positional | theory: ●●●●● | Stockfish d12: +0.45, best Be6

Main line

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5 a6 4.Ba4 Nf6 5.O-O Be7 6.Re1 b5 7.Bb3 d6 8.c3 O-O 9.h3

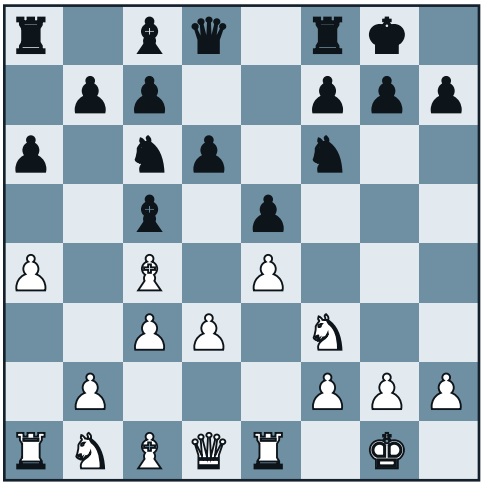
Main idea	Pin and pressure the e5 pawn, build c3 + d4, keep the bishop pair tension on the a2-g8 diagonal.
Pawn structure	Pawns e4/d3 or c3/d4 against e5/d6. Typical outcome: a closed center where White plays d4 at the best moment, or a slow maneuvering game.
Best pieces	Bb3 eyes f7, Nbd2-f1-g3, Re1 backs e4/d4, Qc2/Qe2. The a2-g8 bishop is White's best piece; keep it.
Plan	Complete c3-h3-d4, reroute Nb1 (d2-f1-g3 or Nbd2-b3), then d4 or a kingside attack with Nf5/Bg5. Black counters with ...c5, ...Nc6-a5 and ...Bb7.

Key variations

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5 a6 4.Ba4 Nf6 5.O-O Be7 6.Re1 b5 7.Bb3 O-O 8.a4	Anti-Marshall: hits the b5 pawn and avoids the Marshall.
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5 a6 4.Bxc6 dxc6 5.O-O f6 6.d4 exd4 7.Nxd4 c5 8.Nb3 Qxd1 9.Rxd1 Bg4 10.f3	Exchange Variation: healthier structure (4v3 kingside majority) with a safe endgame.
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5 Nf6 4.O-O Nxe4 5.d4 Nd6 6.Bxc6 dxc6 7.dxe5 Nf5 8.Qxd8+ Kxd8	Berlin Defense: play for a small endgame edge with Nc3, h3 and Rd1.

Watch out: Marshall Gambit (8...d5) is Black's sharp weapon: avoid with 8.a4 (Anti-Marshall) if you do not want to learn it.

Italian Game (Giuoco Pianissimo)



Position after: Re1 a6 e4

A flexible center-building system with little forced theory.

ECO C50-C54 | style: universal | theory: ●●○○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.07, best Ng4

Main line

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Bc5 4.c3 Nf6 5.d3 d6 6.O-O O-O 7.Re1 a6 8.a4

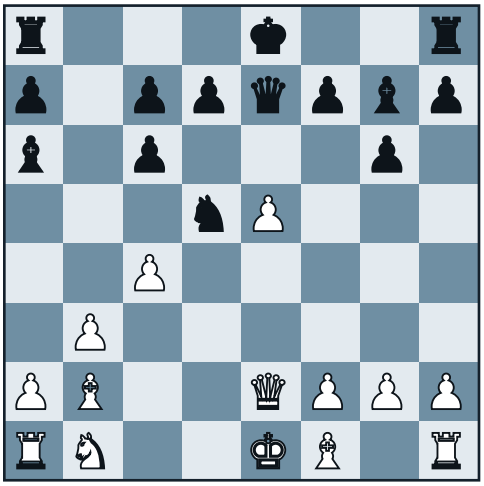
Main idea	Build a d3-c3-e4 pawn center, then redeploy the knight and play d4 when ready. Keeps winning chances without heavy memorization.
Pawn structure	Pawns c3/d3/e4 against d6/e5. The d4 break either opens the position for bishops or gains space if Black allows d4-d5.
Best pieces	Bb3 targets f7, knight d2-f1-g3 (or e3), queen on e2, rook e1 supporting e4.
Plan	a4 (stops ...b5), h3 (stops ...Bg4), Nbd2-f1-g3, then d4. Black's own freeing moves are ...d5 and ...Nh5-f4.

Key variations

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Bc5 4.c3 Nf6 5.d4 exd4 6.cxd4 Bb4+ 7.Nc3 Nxe4 8.O-O Bxc3 9.d5 Bf6 10.Re1 Ne7 11.Rxe4 d6 12.Bg5 Bxg5 13.Nxg5	Moller Attack: sharp, forcing; only if you like theory.
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.d3 Be7 5.O-O O-O 6.Re1 d6 7.c3	Two Knights with d3: avoids Fried Liver and 4.Ng5 theory.
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Bc5 4.b4 Bxb4 5.c3 Be7 6.d4 Na5 7.Be2 exd4 8.Qxd4 Nf6	Evans Gambit: a surprise weapon for fast development.

Watch out: After ...Na5 retreat the bishop to a2 or b5; do not drop the bishop pair for nothing.

Scotch Game



Position after: g6 Bb2 Bg7

Open the center at once; fast development and clear plans.

ECO C44-C45 | style: sharp | theory: ●●●○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.07, best Nd2

Main line

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nxc6 bxc6 6.e5 Qe7 7.Qe2 Nd5 8.c4 Ba6 9.b3 g6 10.Bb2 Bg7

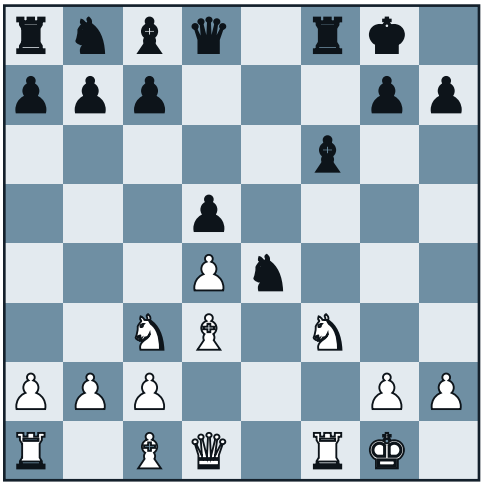
Main idea	Trade the d-pawn for open lines and a central knight, then use space and the bishops.
Pawn structure	Open game: Black gets doubled c-pawns in Mieses lines; White has e4/e5 space. Pieces, not pawns, decide.
Best pieces	Nd4 (or Nxc6), Bc4/Be2, Qe2/Qf3, rooks to d1/e1. Bishops love the open diagonals.
Plan	Develop quickly, castle, and challenge Black's center with c4/f4 or Nd5. If Black plays ...Bc5, use Be3 and Nb5 ideas.

Key variations

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6 6.c3 Nge7 7.Bc4 Ne5 8.Be2	Classical: solid. Keep the pieces behind the c3-d4 pawns.
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Bc4 Nf6 5.e5 d5 6.Bb5 Ne4 7.Nxd4 Bd7 8.Bxc6 bxc6 9.O-O	Scotch Gambit: more initiative, equal-ish.

Watch out: Do not push e5 prematurely if Black can hit it with ...Qe7/...Nd5 and gain tempi.

Vienna Game



Position after: exf6 Bxf6 O-O

A surprise-heavy line: f4 break combined with natural development.

ECO C25-C29 | style: sharp | theory: ●●○○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.39, best Nc6

Main line

1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 d5 4.fxe5 Nxe4 5.Nf3 Be7 6.d4 O-O 7.Bd3 f5 8.exf6 Bxf6 9.O-O

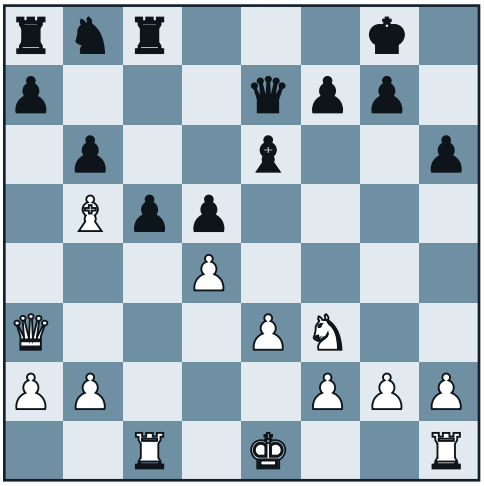
Main idea	Delay Nf3, play f4 when favorable and fight for e4 and the center.
Pawn structure	Open or semi-open center with White space; king safety needs care after f4.
Best pieces	Bc4/Bd3, Nf3, Qe2, long diagonal b2-g7 after d4. Knight c3 supports e4.
Plan	Develop, castle, strike with f4 or d4. In the Bc4 line Black may counter with ...Nxe4; know the tactics.

Key variations

1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Bc4 Nxe4 4.Qh5 Nd6 5.Bb3 Nc6 6.Nb5 g6 7.Qf3 f5 8.Qd5 Qe7 9.Nxc7+ Kd8 10.Nxa8 b6	Frankenstein-Dracula: wild; do not enter unprepared.
1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.d3 Bc5 5.Nf3 d6 6.O-O O-O 7.Bg5	Quiet Vienna: transposes to Italian-style structures with Nc3 and Bg5 pin.

Watch out: Playing 3.Bc4 Nxe4 invites the Frankenstein-Dracula mess: study it or avoid.

Queen's Gambit



Position after: Qa3 Rc8 Bb5

Classical central control with c4 + Nc3 and a rich structure menu.

ECO D06-D69 | style: universal | theory: ●●●●○ | Stockfish d12: -0.17, best a5

Main line

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 Be7 5.e3 O-O 6.Nf3 h6 7.Bh4 b6 8.cxd5 Nxd5 9.Bxe7 Qxe7 10.Nxd5 exd5 11.Rc1 Be6 12.Qa4 c5 13.Qa3 Rc8 14.Bb5

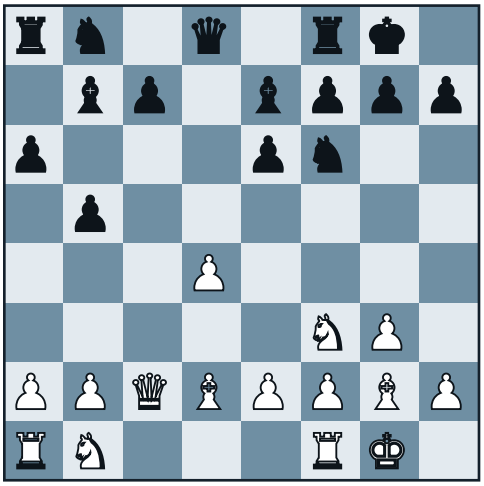
Main idea	Challenge d5 with the c-pawn and play for a stable center, the minority attack or the e4 break.
Pawn structure	Exchange QGD: White a2 b2 e3 vs Black c7 d5 e6 gives the minority attack (b4-b5). QGA: you regain c4 and play with a central majority.
Best pieces	Bg5 pins Nf6, Bd3 aims at h7, Qc2, rooks c1/b1, Knight e5 outpost.
Plan	Develop naturally; exchange on d5 when you want the minority attack; strike with e4 when Black's pieces are passive.

Key variations

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 6.O-O a6 7.Qe2 b5 8.Bb3 Bb7 9.Rd1 Nbd7 10.Nc3 Qb6	QGA: simple development, then e4 or d5.
1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Bg5 c6 6.e3 Be7 7.Bd3 Nbd7 8.Qc2 O-O 9.Nge2 Re8 10.O-O Nf8	Exchange: minority attack plan (Rab1, b4-b5).
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 6.e3 e6 7.Bxc4 Bb4 8.O-O Nbd7	Slav: a4 stops ...b5; trade on c4 and play e4.

Watch out: Do not play Bg5 before Nc3 if ...Ne4 or ...dxc4 gains time. Keep an eye on the c4 pawn in the QGA.

Catalan



Position after: Qc2 Bb7 Bd2

Fianchetto + central pressure: a pure positional edge with low risk.

ECO E04-E09 | style: positional | theory: ●●●○○ | Stockfish d12: -0.03, best Be4

Main line

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O dxc4 7.Qc2 a6 8.Qxc4 b5 9.Qc2 Bb7 10.Bd2

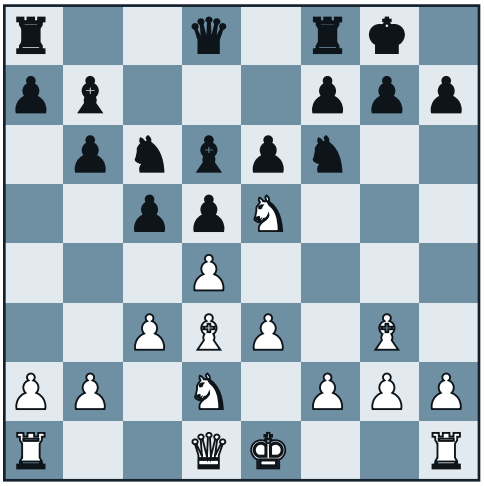
Main idea	Use the long diagonal against d5/b7 and keep a small, lasting initiative.
Pawn structure	Open Catalan: White gets a queenside initiative after taking c4; Closed Catalan: White keeps a central grip and squeezes.
Best pieces	Bg2 (best), knights d2-b3, queen c2, rooks c1/d1. The h1-a8 diagonal is the main asset.
Plan	Pressure c6/d5, play Qc2 and Nbd2, then e4 or queenside expansion with b3, Bb2. In open lines, win back c4 and keep the initiative.

Key variations

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O Nbd7 7.Qc2 c6 8.Nbd2 b6 9.e4 Bb7 10.b3	Closed Catalan: wait with Nbd2 and e4.
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 Bb4+ 4.Bd2 Be7 5.Bg2 d5 6.Nf3 O-O 7.O-O c6 8.Qc2 b6 9.Rc1	Bogo-Indian: respond with Bd2 and quiet development.

Watch out: Black may hold with solid ...c6/...Nbd7; patience is required, not early forcing.

London System



Position after: b6 Ne5 Bb7

A low-theory system you can play against nearly any Black setup.

ECO D00-D02 | style: solid | theory: ●○○○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.05, best O-O

Main line

1.d4 d5 2.Bf4 Nf6 3.e3 c5 4.c3 Nc6 5.Nd2 e6 6.Ngf3 Bd6 7.Bg3 O-O 8.Bd3 b6 9.Ne5 Bb7

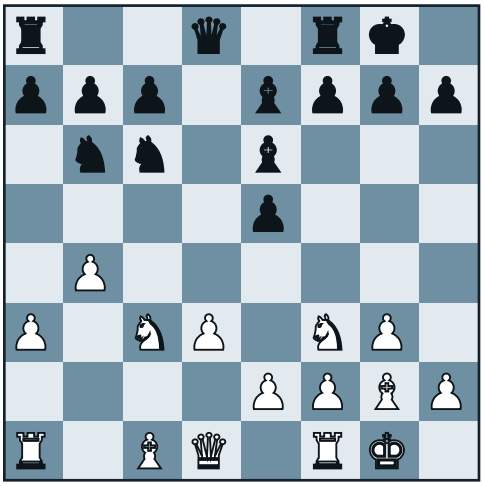
Main idea	Develop the dark bishop first, build c3-d4-e3, and reach familiar positions fast.
Pawn structure	Pyramid c3-d4-e3 with a solid center; the plan is Ne5 + Bd3, or e4, or kingside attack.
Best pieces	Bf4 (or g3) and Bd3 aim at the kingside. Knight d2-f3-e5, queen on c2/e2, rooks e1/f1 for e4.
Plan	Complete the setup, castle, then Ne5, Qf3 or e4. Against ...Qb6, trade queens or defend b2 with Qb3/Qc1.

Key variations

1.d4 Nf6 2.Bf4 g6 3.Nf3 Bg7 4.e3 O-O 5.h3 d6 6.Nbd2 Nbd7 7.c3 e5 8.Bh2 Re8 9.Bd3	Against King's Indian setups: h3 keeps the bishop, then e4.
1.d4 d5 2.Bf4 c5 3.e3 Nc6 4.c3 Qb6 5.Qb3 c4 6.Qxb6 axb6 7.Nd2 e6	Against ...Qb6: trade queens for a safe, healthy structure.

Watch out: Do not let ...c5 + ...Qb6 + ...Nh5 harass the bishop and b2 without a plan.

English Opening



Position after: b4 Be6 d3

Flank control of d5 with c4: flexible and strategic.

ECO A10-A39 | style: positional | theory: ●●●○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.21, best a5

Main line

1.c4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Nf3 Nc6 4.g3 d5 5.cxd5 Nxd5 6.Bg2 Nb6 7.O-O Be7 8.a3 O-O 9.b4 Be6 10.d3

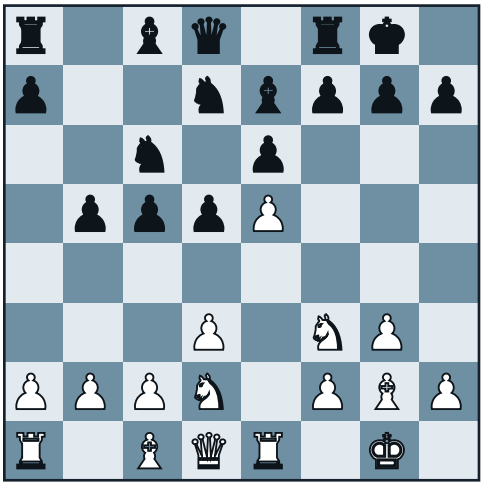
Main idea	Control d5 from the flank, fianchetto the king's bishop and expand with a3-b4.
Pawn structure	Reversed Sicilian: Black often has e5; the d4 square becomes a target and you keep the queenside majority.
Best pieces	Bg2 on the long diagonal, knights c3/f3, Rb1 with b4, queen on c2/a4. A knight on d5 or c3 is a key piece.
Plan	Control d5, castle, Rb1 + a3 + b4, then d3 and Be3/Rc1. Against ...c5 symmetrical setups, play for b4 and d4.

Key variations

1.c4 c5 2.Nc3 Nc6 3.g3 g6 4.Bg2 Bg7 5.Nf3 e6 6.O-O Nge7 7.d3 O-O 8.Rb1 a5 9.a3	Symmetrical: queenside expansion with Rb1 and b4.
1.c4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Nf3 Nc6 4.e3 Bb4 5.Qc2 Bxc3 6.Qxc3 d6 7.b4	Four Knights with e3: pawn center and the bishop pair.

Watch out: Do not allow Black a free ...e5 and ...d5; contest the center with timely d3/e4.

Reti / King's Indian Attack



Position after: b5 e5 Nd7

Hypermodern flexibility: Nf3, g3, Bg2 with no early commitment.

ECO A04-A09 | style: universal | theory: ●●○○○ | Stockfish d12: -0.21, best h4

Main line

1.Nf3 d5 2.g3 Nf6 3.Bg2 e6 4.O-O Be7 5.d3 O-O 6.Nbd2 c5 7.e4 Nc6 8.Re1 b5 9.e5 Nd7

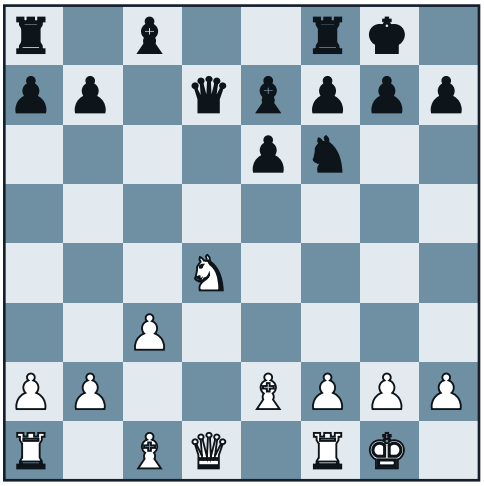
Main idea	Delay pawn commitments, fianchetto, and choose the center based on Black's setup.
Pawn structure	KIA structure: e4-d3 with Bg2; the d3-e4 chain supports a kingside attack, or e5 gains space.
Best pieces	Bg2 (long diagonal), knights d2-f1 or d2-e4, queen on e2, rooks e1/d1.
Plan	Complete the setup, play e4, and launch a kingside attack (Ne5, f4, h4). If Black fianchettoes, switch to c4 ideas.

Key variations

1.Nf3 d5 2.c4 d4 3.e3 Nc6 4.exd4 Nxd4 5.Nxd4 Qxd4 6.Nc3 e5 7.d3 Nf6	Reti Gambit style: open game with piece activity.

Watch out: Do not become passive; transpose to Catalan or English when needed.

Alapin Sicilian (2.c3)



Position after: Nxd4 Nxd4 O-O

Avoid Open-Sicilian theory and build a big center.

ECO B22 | style: solid | theory: ●●○○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.45, best Bf4

Main line

1.e4 c5 2.c3 d5 3.exd5 Qxd5 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 e6 6.Be2 Nc6 7.O-O Be7 8.Na3 cxd4 9.Nb5 Qd7 10.Nbxd4 Nxd4 11.Nxd4 O-O

Main idea	Take the center with c3 + d4 and keep a stable structure; reduce Black's counterplay.
Pawn structure	White gets an IQP or a pawn center after cxd4 cxd4. Plans depend on whether Black takes on d4.
Best pieces	Bishops e2/d3, knights f3/a3-c2, queen c2/e2. Pieces aim at the center and kingside.
Plan	Develop, castle, play d4-d5 or Nc2-e3 to attack. In the Advance Alapin, keep an eye on ...Qb6 and ...c4 breaks.

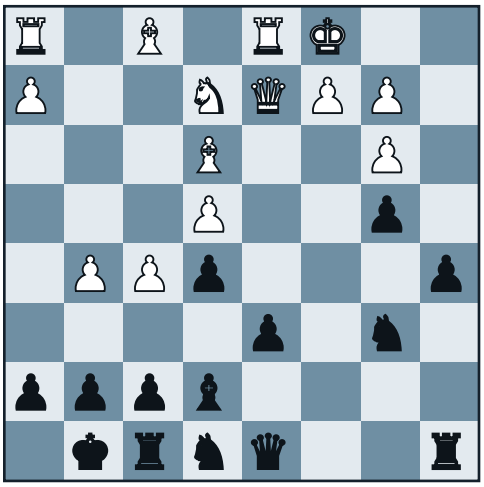
Key variations

1.e4 c5 2.c3 Nf6 3.e5 Nd5 4.d4 cxd4 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.cxd4 d6 7.Bc4 Nb6 8.Bb5 dxe5 9.Nxe5 Bd7 10.Nxd7 Qxd7 11.Bxc6 Qxc6	2...Nf6 line: sharp but principled.
1.e4 c5 2.d4 cxd4 3.c3 dxc3 4.Nxc3 Nc6 5.Nf3 d6 6.Bc4 e6 7.O-O Nf6 8.Qe2 Be7 9.Rd1 e5	Smith-Morra Gambit: a surprise weapon (not the Alapin).

Watch out: Black's ...d5 break can equalize quickly; do not rush the center.

Part III – Black Repertoire

Sicilian Najdorf



Position after: Bxb3 axb3 Nb6 (Black at bottom)

The fighting choice: dynamic imbalance and real winning chances.

ECO B90-B99 | style: sharp | theory: ●●●●● | Stockfish d12: +1.76, best f6

Main line

1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 a6 6.Be3 e5 7.Nb3 Be6 8.f3 Be7 9.Qd2 O-O 10.O-O-O Nbd7 11.g4 b5 12.g5 b4 13.Ne2 Ne8 14.f4 a5 15.f5 Bxb3 16.axb3 Nb6

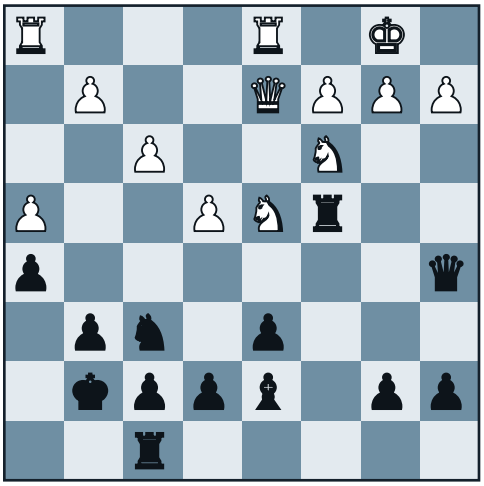
Main idea	Counterattack on the queenside while keeping central options. ...a6 stops Nb5 and prepares ...b5.
Pawn structure	Open Sicilian: Black has d6/e5 or d6/e6; the c-file is open and half-open files give counterplay.
Best pieces	Be7, Rc8, knights d7/b6, queen c7. Pieces aim at the c-file, e4 and b5.
Plan	Complete development, castle, then ...b5, ...Rc8 and ...d5 at the right moment. Versus the English Attack, race with ...b5 and ...Rc8.

Key variations

1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 a6 6.Bg5 e6 7.f4 Be7 8.Qf3 Qc7 9.O-O-O Nbd7 10.g4 b5 11.Bxf6 Nxf6 12.g5 Nd7 13.f5 Ne5	6.Bg5: main line; keep the e5 knight and counterattack.
1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 a6 6.Be2 e5 7.Nb3 Be7 8.O-O O-O 9.Be3 Be6 10.Qd2 Nbd7	Positional 6.Be2: good structure and activity.
1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 a6 6.h3 e5 7.Nde2 h5 8.g3 Nc6 9.Bg2 Be6 10.O-O Rc8	6.h3: ...e5 and ...h5 are standard.

Watch out: The sharp lines (6.Bg5, English Attack) need exact memory; if you want less theory, play ...e6 Scheveningen setups.

Sicilian Dragon



Position after: Rxc4 Kb1 Qa5 (Black at bottom)

A bishop on the long diagonal plus open c- and d-files: very sharp.

ECO B70-B79 | style: sharp | theory: ●●●●● | Stockfish d12: +0.43, best g4

Main line

1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 g6 6.Be3 Bg7 7.f3 O-O 8.Qd2 Nc6 9.Bc4 Bd7 10.O-O-O Rc8 11.Bb3 Ne5 12.h4 h5 13.Bh6 Nc4 14.Bxg7 Kxg7 15.Bxc4 Rxc4 16.Kb1 Qa5

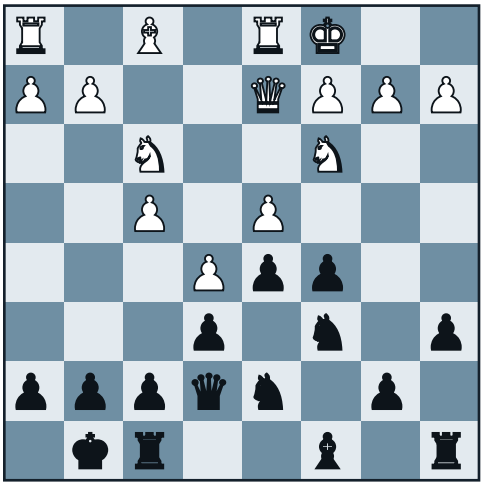
Main idea	Counterattack on the queenside while the g7 bishop dominates the long diagonal.
Pawn structure	Open c-file, d6 pawn chain; White's king often castles long, Black's rook sacrifices on c3 are typical.
Best pieces	Bg7 (monster), rooks c8/c4, knight c6/e5, queen a5/c7.
Plan	Complete development, trade pieces on c4 if possible, play ...Rc8 and ...a5 or ...Qa5, and attack on the c-file.

Key variations

1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 g6 6.Be2 Bg7 7.O-O Nc6 8.Nb3 Be6 9.f4 O-O 10.Kh1 Na5 11.f5 Bc4 12.Bxc4 Nxc4	Classical: a calmer way to meet the Dragon.
1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 g6 6.g3 Bg7 7.Bg2 Nc6 8.Nb3 O-O 9.O-O Be6	Fianchetto: solid for White, still dynamic for Black.

Watch out: The Yugoslav Attack is a race: you need exact move orders. Not for those who dislike memorization.

French Defense



Position after: Nc6 O-O-O a6 (Black at bottom)

Solid central structure with counterplay against the d4 pawn.

ECO C00-C19 | style: solid | theory: ●●●●○ | Stockfish d12: +0.38, best Ne2

Main line

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 Be7 5.e5 Nfd7 6.Bxe7 Qxe7 7.f4 O-O 8.Nf3 c5 9.Qd2 Nc6 10.O-O-O a6

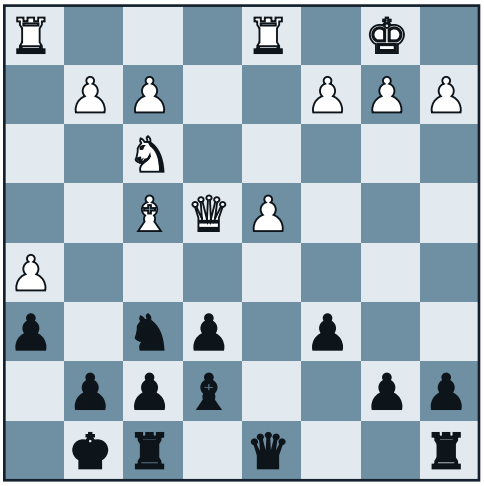
Main idea	Challenge the center with ...d5 and ...c5, accepting a slightly cramped position for strong counterplay.
Pawn structure	French pawn chain: White e5/d4 vs Black e6/d5. Black's light-squared bishop is the 'bad piece'; improve it with ...b6 or ...Bd7.
Best pieces	Knights to c6/e7, queen on b6/c7, dark bishop for activity. Black's rooks aim at the c-file.
Plan	Strike with ...c5 and ...f6 to undermine e5; trade the bad bishop and counterattack on the queenside.

Key variations

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 c5 4.c3 Nc6 5.Nf3 Qb6 6.a3 c4 7.Nbd2 Na5 8.Be2 Bd7 9.O-O Rc8	Advance: pressure d4 and keep the queenside play.
1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 Nf6 4.e5 Nfd7 5.Bd3 c5 6.c3 Nc6 7.Ne2 cxd4 8.cxd4 f6 9.exf6 Nxf6 10.Nf3 Bd6 11.O-O O-O	Tarrasch: active pieces, healthy structure.
1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e5 c5 5.a3 Bxc3+ 6.bxc3 Ne7 7.Qg4 Qc7 8.Qxg7 Rg8 9.Qxh7 cxd4 10.Ne2 Nbc6 11.f4 Bd7	Winawer: sharp, imbalanced; for experienced players.

Watch out: In the Advance and Winawer, know the move orders: White may play for a king attack.

Caro-Kann



Position after: Nxe4 Qxe4 Nf6 (Black at bottom)

Rock-solid against 1.e4 with a healthy pawn structure and endgame appeal.

ECO B10-B19 | style: solid | theory: ●●●○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.49, best Qd3

Main line

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5 5.Ng3 Bg6 6.h4 h6 7.Nf3 Nd7 8.h5 Bh7 9.Bd3 Bxd3 10.Qxd3 e6 11.Bf4 Ngf6 12.O-O-O Be7 13.Kb1 O-O 14.Ne4 Nxe4 15.Qxe4 Nf6

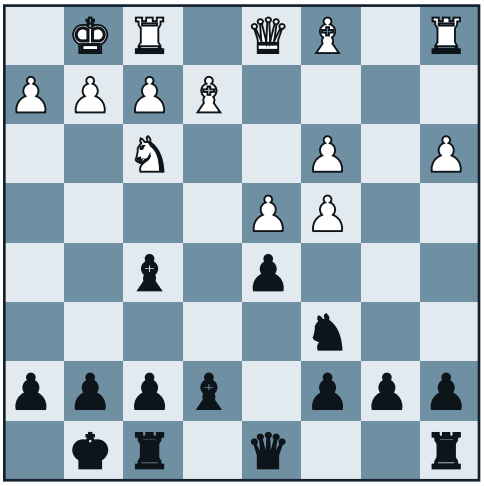
Main idea	Support d5 with c6, develop the light bishop before ...e6, and play with a healthy pawn structure.
Pawn structure	Classical: Black has c6/e6 with no weaknesses. Advance: White gets space, Black counters with ...c5.
Best pieces	Bf5/g6 out early, knights f6/d7, queen c7/d8, rooks c8/d8. Dark bishop e7 or d6 as needed.
Plan	Develop ...Nf6/Nd7, ...e6, ...Bd6 or Be7, then strike with ...c5 or ...e5. In the Advance, challenge the chain with ...c5.

Key variations

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 Bf5 4.Nf3 e6 5.Be2 c5 6.Be3 cxd4 7.Nxd4 Nc6 8.Nd2 Nge7 9.N2b3 Ng6	Advance: attack d4, then ...Nc6 and ...Qb6.
1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.Bd3 Nc6 5.c3 Nf6 6.Bf4 Bg4 7.Qb3 Qd7 8.Nd2 e6 9.Ngf3 Bd6	Exchange: active bishop g4 and queen d7.
1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 e6 6.Nf3 Be7 7.cxd5 Nxd5 8.Bd3 Nc6 9.O-O O-O 10.Re1 Bf6	Panov: IQP structure; play for piece activity.

Watch out: In the Panov (4.c4), avoid a passive IQP structure; choose active piece play.

Petroff Defense



Position after: Nxc3 bxc3 Nc6 (Black at bottom)

A symmetrical, drawish choice: safe and hard to beat.

ECO C42-C43 | style: solid | theory: ●●●○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.43, best Re1

Main line

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 d5 6.Bd3 Nc6 7.O-O Be7 8.c4 Nb4 9.Be2 O-O 10.Nc3 Bf5 11.a3 Nxc3 12.bxc3 Nc6

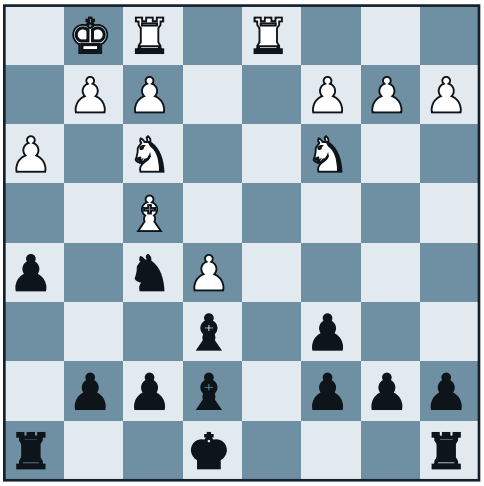
Main idea	Counterattack e4 immediately; reach a symmetrical structure where White has little to attack.
Pawn structure	Symmetrical pawn structure; the game is about piece activity and small endgame edges.
Best pieces	Knights e4/f6, bishops e7/f5, queen d7/e8, rooks e8/d8.
Plan	Complete development, hit the center with ...c5 or ...Nb4, and look for equalizing exchanges.

Key variations

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.Qe2 Qe7 6.d3 Nf6 7.Bg5 Qxe2+ 8.Bxe2 Be7 9.Nc3 Nbd7	5.Qe2: simplify to a safe endgame.
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.d4 Nxe4 4.Bd3 d5 5.Nxe5 Nd7 6.Nxd7 Bxd7 7.O-O Bd6 8.c4 c6 9.Nc3 Nxc3 10.bxc3 O-O	3.d4: Black plays ...Nxe4 and aims for equality.

Watch out: White can play for a small edge with Nc3 and h3; avoid passivity.

Ruy Lopez: Berlin Defense



Position after: Be7 Rad1 Be6 (Black at bottom)

A solid endgame-oriented defense to 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5.

ECO C65-C67 | style: solid | theory: ●●●○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.42, best Ng5

Main line

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5 Nf6 4.O-O Nxe4 5.d4 Nd6 6.Bxc6 dxc6 7.dxe5 Nf5 8.Qxd8+ Kxd8 9.Nc3 Ke8 10.h3 h5 11.Bf4 Be7 12.Rad1 Be6

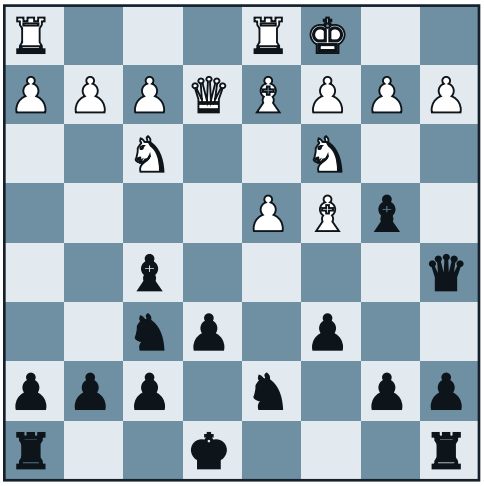
Main idea	Trade queens early and rely on the bishop pair and a stable structure; White has a small edge but Black is safe.
Pawn structure	Black has doubled c-pawns but the bishop pair and open lines compensate; the structure is solid.
Best pieces	Bishops e6/e7, knight f5/d7, king e8, rooks d8/h8.
Plan	Complete development, play ...Ke8, ...h5 and ...Be6; use the bishop pair and keep the pawn majority.

Key variations

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5 Nf6 4.d3 Bc5 5.c3 O-O 6.Bxc6 dxc6 7.Nbd2 Nd7 8.Nc4 f6	4.d3: simple development, equal game.

Watch out: White's endgame edge is small, but you need patience.

Scandinavian Defense



Position after: Bb4 O-O-O Nbd7 (Black at bottom)

Immediate central challenge: easy to learn, solid and active.

ECO B01 | style: universal | theory: ●●○○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.31, best Bb3

Main line

1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 c6 6.Bc4 Bf5 7.Bd2 e6 8.Qe2 Bb4 9.O-O-O Nbd7

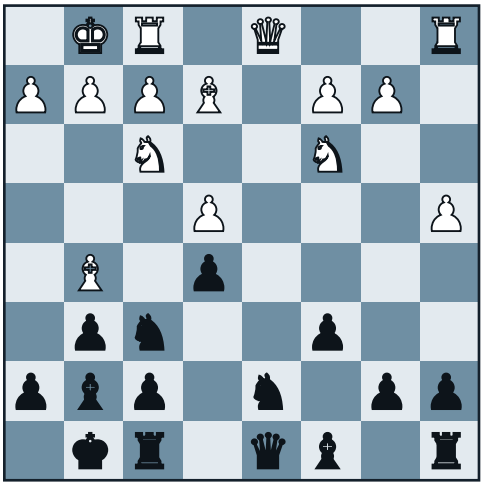
Main idea	Take the pawn back with the queen and develop quickly; accept an early queen move for solid structure.
Pawn structure	Black has a flexible structure; the queen on a5/d6 is active but exposed to tempo.
Best pieces	Bf5 outside the chain, knights f6/d7, Bb4 pin, queen a5/d6.
Plan	Develop, castle, then ...c5 or ...e5 breaks. Avoid wasting time with the queen.

Key variations

1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qd6 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 c6 6.h3 Bf5 7.Ne5 Nbd7 8.Nxd7 Nxd7 9.g4 Bg6	3...Qd6: more modern, safe queen position.
1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Nxd5 4.Nf3 g6 5.Be2 Bg7 6.O-O O-O 7.c4 Nb6 8.Nc3 Nc6	2...Nf6: gambit-style, a solid alternative.

Watch out: White gains tempi with Nc3; do not overextend the queen.

Pirc Defense



Position after: dxe5 dxe5 Bg5 (Black at bottom)

A hypermodern defense: allow White a big center, then attack it.

ECO B07-B09 | style: universal | theory: ●●●○○ | Stockfish d12: -0.18, best Nc5

Main line

1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Be2 O-O 6.O-O c6 7.a4 Nbd7 8.Be3 e5 9.dxe5 dxe5 10.Bg5

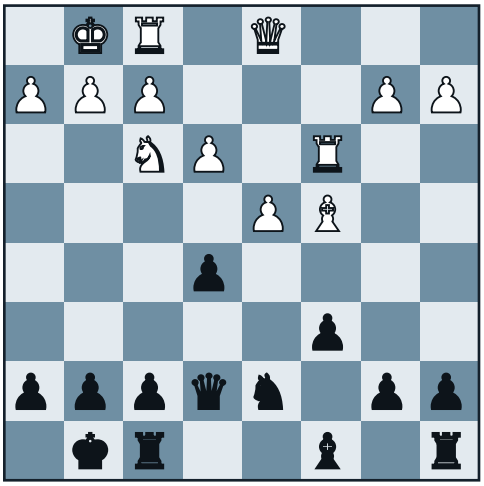
Main idea	Fianchetto and counterattack the center with ...c5 or ...e5.
Pawn structure	Hypermodern structure: White e4/d4 vs Black d6/g6/Bg7. Black counterattacks with ...c5, ...e5.
Best pieces	Bg7 is the key piece; knights d7/f6, queen c7/b6.
Plan	Complete development, castle, and strike with ...e5 or ...c5. Against the Austrian Attack, strike with ...c5.

Key variations

1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 Bg7 5.Nf3 c5 6.dxc5 Qa5 7.Bd3 Qxc5 8.Qe2 O-O 9.Be3 Qa5 10.O-O Bg4	Austrian Attack: counter with ...c5.
1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Be3 c6 5.Qd2 b5 6.f3 Nbd7 7.Bd3 Bb7 8.Nge2 Bg7	150 Attack: ...c6 and ...b5.

Watch out: The Austrian Attack (4.f4) and 150 Attack are sharp; know your lines.

Queen's Gambit Declined



Position after: Nxc3 Rxc3 e5 (Black at bottom)

Classical and solid: control e4 and develop with a healthy structure.

ECO D30-D69 | style: solid | theory: ●●●●○ | Stockfish d12: +0.60, best d5

Main line

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 Be7 5.e3 O-O 6.Nf3 Nbd7 7.Rc1 c6 8.Bd3 dxc4 9.Bxc4 Nd5 10.Bxe7 Qxe7 11.O-O Nxc3 12.Rxc3 e5

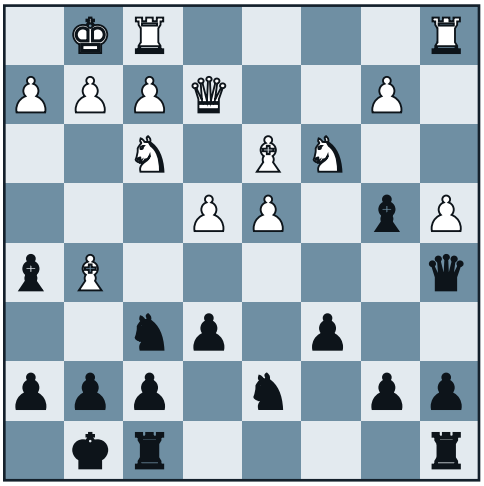
Main idea	Hold d5, keep a solid structure and free your position with ...c5 or ...e5.
Pawn structure	Orthodox QGD: Black d5/e6 vs White c4/d4; the c8 bishop is initially passive but the structure is sturdy.
Best pieces	Knights d7/f6, Be7, queen e7/c7, rook c8/d8. The light bishop develops to b7 or b4 later.
Plan	Play ...c5 or ...e5 when ready; trade a pair of minor pieces to relieve the cramp; aim for ...Ne4 ideas.

Key variations

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Nf3 Be7 5.Bf4 O-O 6.e3 c5 7.dxc5 Bxc5 8.a3 Nc6 9.Qc2 Qa5 10.Rd1 Rd8	4.Nf3/Bf4: play ...c5 and activate the pieces.
1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Bg5 Be7 6.e3 Nbd7 7.Bd3 O-O 8.Qc2 c6 9.Nge2 Re8 10.O-O Nf8	Exchange: defend vs the minority attack with ...Ne4, ...a5.

Watch out: Do not leave the bishop c8 locked forever; plan ...b6 and ...Bb7 or ...c5.

Slav / Semi-Slav



Position after: Bh5 Bg5 Qa5 (Black at bottom)

Solid with an active light bishop; a favorite of world champions.

ECO D10-D19, D43-D49 | style: universal | theory: ●●●●○ | Stockfish d12: +0.11, best e5

Main line

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 6.e3 e6 7.Bxc4 Bb4 8.O-O Nbd7 9.Qe2 Bg6 10.e4 O-O 11.Bd3 Bh5 12.Bg5 Qa5

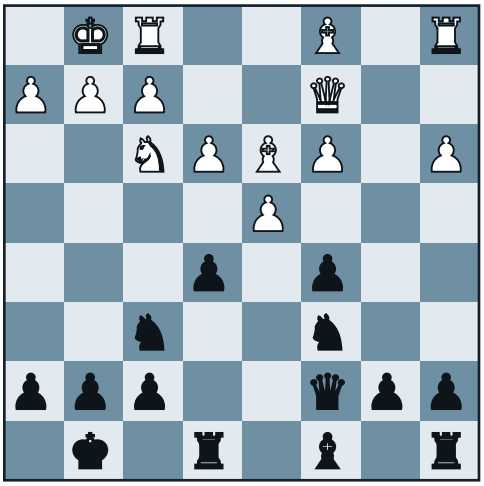
Main idea	Support d5 with c6, develop the light bishop outside the chain, then ...e6.
Pawn structure	Slav: c6/d5 pawns with an active c8 bishop. Semi-Slav: e6/c6/d5 chain with ...dxc4 and ...b5 break.
Best pieces	Bf5/g4 outside the chain, knight d7/f6, Bb4 or e7, queen c7/b6.
Plan	Gain the center with ...e5 or ...c5; use the bishop pair and the b5 break in the Semi-Slav.

Key variations

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.cxd5 cxd5 5.Nc3 Nc6 6.Bf4 Bf5 7.e3 e6 8.Qb3 Bb4 9.Bb5 Bxc3+ 10.bxc3 Qd7	Exchange Slav: symmetrical, play for ...Bb4.
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.e3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 8.Bd3 a6 9.e4 c5 10.e5 cxd4 11.Nxb5 axb5 12.exf6 gxf6 13.O-O Bb7	Meran: sharp, tactical, requires memory.

Watch out: Do not overextend the queen side; White's e4 can be dangerous if Black falls behind in development.

Nimzo-Indian



Position after: e5 Qc2 Re8 (Black at bottom)

Pin the knight on c3 and fight for e4; a top-level classic.

ECO E20-E59 | style: universal | theory: ●●●●○ | Stockfish d12: +0.16, best e4

Main line

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 7.O-O Nc6 8.a3 Bxc3 9.bxc3 dxc4 10.Bxc4 Qc7 11.Bd3 e5 12.Qc2 Re8

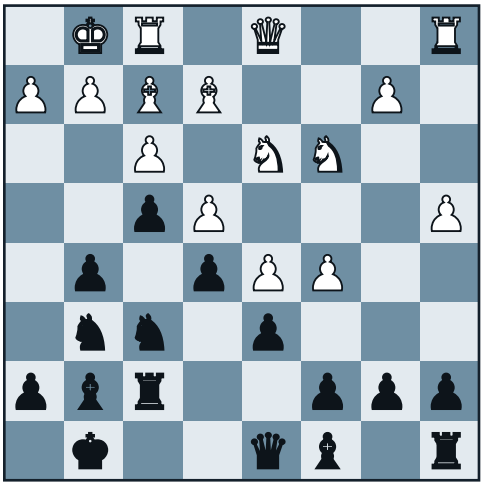
Main idea	Control e4 with the pin and play for ...c5/...d5 or ...b6 setups; give up the bishop pair for structure.
Pawn structure	Hanging pawns or a doubled-c structure for White after Bxc3; Black has flexible pawn breaks.
Best pieces	Bb4 pin, knights c6/f6, queen c7/e7, rooks e8/d8.
Plan	Keep the pin, take on c3 only if favorable, then play ...d5 or ...c5 with piece activity.

Key variations

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 O-O 5.a3 Bxc3+ 6.Qxc3 b6 7.Bg5 Bb7 8.e3 d6 9.f3 Nbd7 10.Bd3 h6 11.Bh4 c5	Classical: ...b6 and ...Bb7 target e4.
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.f3 d5 5.a3 Bxc3+ 6.bxc3 c5 7.cxd5 Nxd5 8.dxc5 f5 9.e4 fxe4 10.fxe4 Nf6	Samisch: ...c5 and ...f5 hit the center.
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Nf3 c5 5.e3 Nc6 6.Bd3 Bxc3+ 7.bxc3 d6 8.e4 e5 9.d5 Ne7 10.Nh4 h6	4.Nf3: ...c5 and a dynamic center.

Watch out: Know the Rubinstein (4.e3) and Classical (4.Qc2) to avoid surprises.

King's Indian Defense



Position after: Nf6 c5 Rf7 (Black at bottom)

Hypermodern counterattack: let White build, then strike.

ECO E60-E99 | style: sharp | theory: ●●●●○ | Stockfish d12: +0.96, best a5

Main line

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 Bg7 4.e4 d6 5.Nf3 O-O 6.Be2 e5 7.O-O Nc6 8.d5 Ne7 9.Ne1 Nd7 10.Be3 f5 11.f3 f4 12.Bf2 g5 13.a4 Ng6 14.Nd3 Nf6 15.c5 Rf7

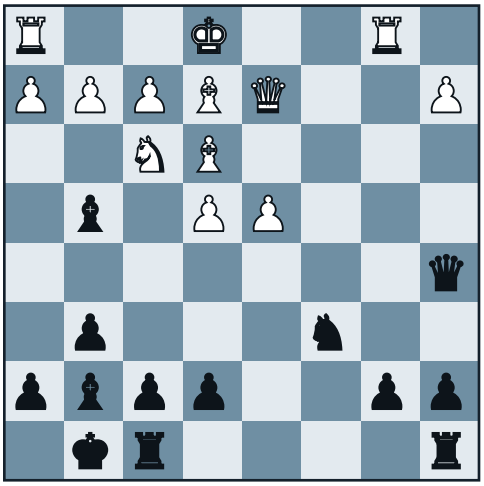
Main idea	Allow White a big center, then attack it with ...e5 and ...f5. The g7 bishop becomes a monster once the center locks.
Pawn structure	Locked center: White c4-d5-e4 vs Black d6-e5. White plays c5 on the queenside; Black plays ...f5-f4 and ...g5 on the kingside.
Best pieces	Bg7 (best), knights e8/d7/g6, queen e8/e7, rooks f8/g8.
Plan	Castle, ...e5, ...Nbd7, ...Ne8, then ...f5 and a pawn storm (...f4, ...g5). If White opens the center, use the bishop and e-file.

Key variations

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 Bg7 4.e4 d6 5.f3 O-O 6.Be3 e5 7.Nge2 c6 8.Qd2 Nbd7 9.O-O-O a6 10.Kb1 b5	Samisch: race with ...c6, ...b5 vs the king.
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.g3 Bg7 4.Bg2 O-O 5.Nc3 d6 6.Nf3 Nbd7 7.O-O e5 8.e4 c6 9.h3 Qb6 10.Re1 Re8	Fianchetto: hold e5, play ...c6 and ...Qb6.
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 Bg7 4.e4 d6 5.Be2 O-O 6.Bg5 c5 7.d5 e6 8.Qd2 exd5 9.exd5 Re8 10.Nf3 Bg4	Averbakh: ...c5 and ...e6 break the center.

Watch out: Do not push ...f5 too early before pieces are ready; know the Samisch and Bayonet.

Grunfeld Defense



Position after: cxd4 cxd4 Nc6 (Black at bottom)

Dynamic counterplay: concede the center and hit it with pieces.

ECO D70-D99 | style: sharp | theory: ●●●●● | Stockfish d12: +0.62, best Qxa5

Main line

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.cxd5 Nxd5 5.e4 Nxc3 6.bxc3 Bg7 7.Nf3 c5 8.Be3 Qa5 9.Qd2 Bg4 10.Rb1 O-O 11.Be2 cxd4 12.cxd4 Nc6

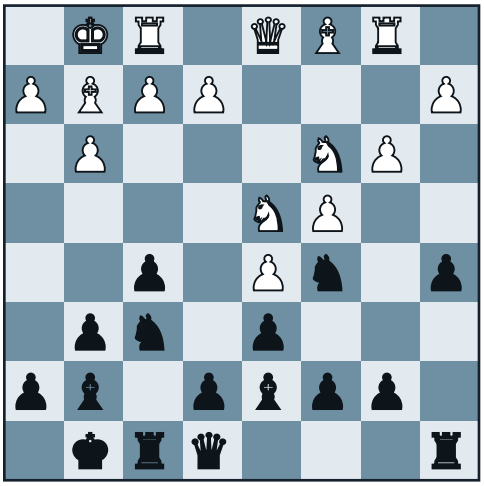
Main idea	Allow a big pawn center and attack it with pieces, ...c5 and the g7 bishop.
Pawn structure	White has a broad center (c3, d4, e4); Black has a flexible, mobile piece setup.
Best pieces	Bg7 hits d4, queen a5, knight c6, bishop g4, rooks c8/d8.
Plan	Pressure d4, trade pieces, and attack the center before White can consolidate; endgames favor Black if White's center is weak.

Key variations

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Qb3 dxc4 6.Qxc4 O-O 7.e4 Bg4 8.Be3 Nfd7 9.Qb3 Nb6 10.Rd1 Nc6	Russian: active piece play with ...Bg4 and ...Nc6.
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Bg7 5.cxd5 Nxd5 6.e4 Nb6 7.Ne2 O-O 8.O-O Nc6 9.Nbc3 e5	Fianchetto: ...e5 and ...Nb6 are key.

Watch out: The Exchange and Russian lines are theory-heavy; the pawn center can be dangerous if you slip.

Dutch Defense (Leningrad / Stonewall)



Position after: a5 b3 Bd7 (Black at bottom)

Fight for e4 with an ...f5 setup; unbalanced and surprising.

ECO A80-A99 | style: sharp | theory: ●●●○○ | Stockfish d12: +0.40, best Qc2

Main line

1.d4 f5 2.g3 Nf6 3.Bg2 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.O-O O-O 6.c4 d6 7.Nc3 Qe8 8.d5 Na6 9.Rb1 Nc5 10.Nd4 a5 11.b3 Bd7

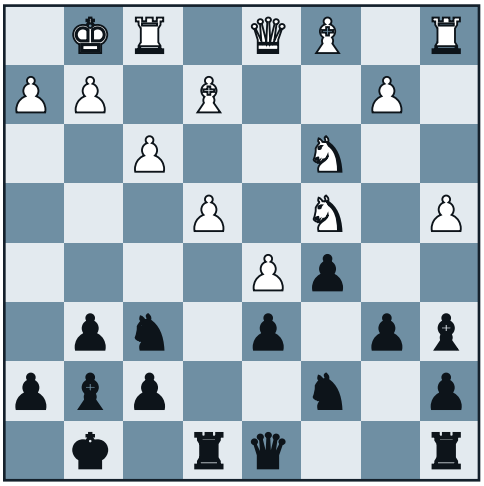
Main idea	Control e4, build a kingside attack, and choose between a Leningrad or Stonewall structure.
Pawn structure	Leningrad: ...f5/...d6/...g6 with Bg7 for kingside play. Stonewall: pawns on f5/e6/d5 with an outpost on e4.
Best pieces	Bg7 (Leningrad) or Ne4 with a bishop on d6 (Stonewall), queen e8-h5, rooks f8/e8.
Plan	Complete the setup, then ...e5 (Leningrad) or ...Ne4 and ...Bd6 (Stonewall) with kingside attack.

Key variations

1.d4 e6 2.c4 f5 3.g3 Nf6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nc3 O-O 6.Nf3 d5 7.O-O c6 8.Qc2 Qe8 9.Ne5 Nbd7	Stonewall: strong e4 outpost; fight for the dark squares.
1.d4 f5 2.e4 fxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 e6 5.Nxe4 Be7 6.Bxf6 Bxf6 7.Nf3 O-O 8.Bd3 b6 9.Qe2 Bb7	Staunton Gambit: accept and defend accurately.

Watch out: The e1-h4 diagonal and e6 weaknesses need care; White's Bf4 and Ne5 can be annoying.

Modern Benoni



Position after: b6 Nc4 Ba6 (Black at bottom)

Unbalanced pawn structure: Black gets piece activity and queenside play.

ECO A60-A79 | style: sharp | theory: ●●●●○ | Stockfish d12: +0.62, best Bg5

Main line

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.Nf3 Bg7 8.Be2 O-O 9.O-O Re8 10.Nd2 Na6 11.f3 Nc7 12.a4 b6 13.Nc4 Ba6

Main idea	Play ...e6/...c5 to get a queenside majority and active pieces versus White's central space.
Pawn structure	White has an e4-d5 center and a kingside majority; Black has a 3-v-2 queenside majority and the d6 and e5 squares.
Best pieces	Bg7 and rook e8 pressure e4; knights c7/a6, ...b5 break, ...Bf5/g4 for activity.
Plan	Prepare ...b5 and ...Nc7, trade the pieces that guard e4, and use the open g7 diagonal.

Key variations

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.f4 Bg7 8.Bb5+ Nfd7 9.a4 O-O 10.Nf3 Na6 11.O-O Nb6 12.Qe2 Bg4	Taimanov Attack: ...Nfd7 and ...Na6 are key.
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.Nf3 Bg7 8.g3 O-O 9.Bg2 Re8 10.O-O Na6 11.Bf4 Nh5	Fianchetto: hit e4 and trade the f4 bishop.

Watch out: White's e4-e5 break and Bb5+ lines are sharp; know your move orders.

Part IV – Repertoire Builder

Choose openings that match your style and the time you can invest. The engine ranks openings by style match first, then by how light the theory is.

Opening	Side	Style	Theory	ECO
Ruy Lopez (Closed)	White	positional	5/5	C84-C99
Italian Game (Giuoco Pianissimo)	White	universal	2/5	C50-C54
Scotch Game	White	sharp	3/5	C44-C45
Vienna Game	White	sharp	2/5	C25-C29
Queen's Gambit	White	universal	4/5	D06-D69
Catalan	White	positional	3/5	E04-E09
London System	White	solid	1/5	D00-D02
English Opening	White	positional	3/5	A10-A39
Reti / King's Indian Attack	White	universal	2/5	A04-A09
Alapin Sicilian (2.c3)	White	solid	2/5	B22
Sicilian Najdorf	Black	sharp	5/5	B90-B99
Sicilian Dragon	Black	sharp	5/5	B70-B79
French Defense	Black	solid	4/5	C00-C19
Caro-Kann	Black	solid	3/5	B10-B19
Petroff Defense	Black	solid	3/5	C42-C43
Ruy Lopez: Berlin Defense	Black	solid	3/5	C65-C67
Scandinavian Defense	Black	universal	2/5	B01
Pirc Defense	Black	universal	3/5	B07-B09
Queen's Gambit Declined	Black	solid	4/5	D30-D69
Slav / Semi-Slav	Black	universal	4/5	D10-D19, D43-D49
Nimzo-Indian	Black	universal	4/5	E20-E59
King's Indian Defense	Black	sharp	4/5	E60-E99
Grunfeld Defense	Black	sharp	5/5	D70-D99
Dutch Defense (Leningrad / Stonewall)	Black	sharp	3/5	A80-A99
Modern Benoni	Black	sharp	4/5	A60-A79

Ready-made repertoires (generated by the engine)

Solid & low-risk

White: Alapin Sicilian (2.c3), London System, English Opening, Reti / King's Indian Attack, Italian Game (Giuoco Pianissimo), Vienna Game
Black: Caro-Kann, Petroff Defense, Dutch Defense (Leningrad / Stonewall)

Universal / balanced

White: Italian Game (Giuoco Pianissimo), Queen's Gambit, English Opening, Reti / King's Indian Attack, London System, Vienna Game

Black: Scandinavian Defense, Pirc Defense, Slav / Semi-Slav, Nimzo-Indian

Aggressive / maximum winning chances

White: Vienna Game, Queen's Gambit, English Opening, Reti / King's Indian Attack, Scotch Game, Italian Game (Giuoco Pianissimo)
Black: Sicilian Najdorf, Sicilian Dragon, Dutch Defense (Leningrad / Stonewall), King's Indian Defense

Quick answers to rare first moves (Black)

• **1.c4**: ...e5 (reversed Sicilian) or ...c5/...Nf6 symmetrical setups; or ...e6 with ...d5 (QGD structures).

• **1.Nf3**: ...d5 and ...c6 (Slav setup) or ...Nf6 followed by ...g6 (King's Indian setup).

• **1.b3 / 1.g3 / 1.f4**: ...d5 and ...Nf6, take the center and develop naturally; against 1.f4 use ...d5 and ...Nf6 (Stonewall-like), or the Dutch reversed.

• **1.d4 d5 2.Bf4 / Colle**: ...c5 with ...Qb6 vs the London; ...Nf6, ...e6, ...Bd6 vs Colle.

Checklist before every tournament

• Review your main lines the day before; do not learn new theory the night before.

• Know the first 10 moves of every opening; know the first break and the first plan.

• Prepare one surprise weapon (Scotch, Vienna, Evans, Scandinavian) for stronger opponents.

• After each game, add one new idea or correction to your notes.